

HUMAN HISTORY

Our history

The history of humanity is not the history of a progressive liberation, nor that of a continuous degeneration.

It is the history of a species capable of building what no individual could have built alone and, at the same time, of using that very capacity to dominate, exploit and destroy.

As human beings, we have cooperated in order to survive, we have shared knowledge, built communities, founded cities, we have developed medicine, philosophy, the scientific method, law, art! We have crossed oceans, observed the sky, transformed energy, defeated diseases and enormously increased the material possibilities of the life of each one of us.

And yet.

It is these same capacities of ours that have produced, as their counterpart, hierarchies, power, domination, and control.

What accompanied our capacity for cooperation from the very start was competition. Territory became property, force became authority, authority became institution, the institution became the State.

The State, which has certainly made possible a capacity for organisation until then unknown to small communities, but which also from the very start concentrated instruments of coercion and control over ever vaster territories and populations.

We have built kingdoms and empires, with the aid of war, conquest and the subordination of other peoples. Monarchies, aristocracies, empires and religious systems organised collective life for centuries, distributing freedom, wealth, knowledge and power in a profoundly unequal way.

How many people in the course of history have been reduced to slavery, deported, exploited or deprived of their autonomy? How many still today? Entire populations conquered, assimilated, expelled or exterminated.

There is therefore no single history of humankind.

There are the histories of peoples, some who built, others who were conquered, others who even resisted, among those who dominated and those who were dominated.

Power has a recurring characteristic still today: whoever controls resources, weapons, information or institutions has a greater capacity to determine the lives of others.

Modernity does not erase this dynamic.

It transforms it.

The scientific revolution widened knowledge. Industrialisation multiplied productive capacity. Constitutions limited certain powers. Civil and political rights expanded.

And yet.

States go on fighting wars. We go on being divided by borders, interests, identities, religions, ideologies and competition.

A species born to survive in small groups, with the capacity today to alter ecosystems and possibly annihilate entire populations at the press of a button by "one" who chooses for all.

We have attained a capacity to intervene in the world immensely greater than our historical capacity to govern its consequences.

We have become more powerful without becoming wiser.

We produce more without knowing how to distribute.

We have increased the capacity to communicate without eliminating loneliness.

We have widened knowledge and, I have the impression, ignorance too.

We have recognised universal rights without managing to guarantee them universally. Surely we are not just a simple succession of failures?

And yet.

We have produced ideas capable of reaching beyond tribes, cities, empires, religions and nations.

We have conceived the idea that dignity belongs not only to the member of one's own community, or to whoever suits us, but to the human being as such.

And so I ask myself.

Why did we allow it to happen?

I do not believe that we simply chose, in every age, to live under someone's domination.

We had no alternative.

We were born into it. And adapted.

The human being is capable of building systems that can produce as much good as suffering, and then of living inside those systems long enough to forget having built them.

And here lies perhaps one of the deepest capacities of social systems: to transform their own historical conditions into something that individuals perceive as inevitable.

And yet.

Empires have fallen.

Monarchies overthrown.

Rights won.

Constitutions rewritten.

Borders changed.

Millions of individuals, organised through institutions, can build a civilisation.

And the same millions of individuals, organised through different institutions, can build different civilisations.

A society must also be judged by the rules through which it transforms individual actions into collective consequences.

We have inherited much of the world in which we live, but inheriting a system does not mean being condemned to preserve it. We have already shown that we can change, more than once, what seemed immutable.

So perhaps the question now is not

why we have not been capable of building a better society.

It is: for how much longer will we go on considering this system inevitable?

We cannot entrust the future to someone's virtue.

We certainly cannot entrust it to the benevolence of those who hold power.

It is up to us to decide whether to confine ourselves to inheriting the future or to begin building it.